A1

FOR ANY SYSTEM of TTRPG

Dungeon Module A1
Rats In The Cradle

by Dirk Wiggley

AN ADVENTURE FOR CHARACTER LEVELS 1-100



In the capital city of Everward a curse has taken hold of the head of a powerful family. The passage of time warps his soul and leads down the path to madness. An army will be needed to fulfil thier liederkranz desires. Nowhere in the city is safe, is it's feta sealed, will a champion of gouda come to it's rescue? The party must hurry before a the wererat puppet masters unleash hellim.

This adventure module contains a bunch of pages of storylines for lycanthropic coup against the city. The action, including timelines for events, story options for GMs and players, descriptions of locations and NPCs, and maps and images of locations are all included. This adventure for up to eight characters of 1st to 100th level is not to be underestimated!

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VANCOUVER, WA

About this module

The cover of this module was made from a Gimp template freely provided by a Redditor named IcarusAvery, https://www.reddit.com/user/IcarusAvery/

Some of the images used were generated by AI. Since I'm not charging for this module I don't feel too bad about that though I do regret not spending more time in art class.

This module is game system agnostic. It does not contain statistics for any game system. Elements of this module that would ordinarily have system specific statistics are described in general terms and the translation into the game of your choice is up to the reader.

I encourage game masters to read this module from start to finish and then go back through it to make notes about relevant information in the game system of your choice before playing.

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The current revision of this document is 1.0

About the Author

I began playing D&D in the late 1970s and am a fan of fantasy and science fiction in print and other media. Like all other DMs I shamelessly steal ideas from other works and inject my own unique sensibilities into them. Many of my campaigns have lasted years with my longest going about eighteen years. So I can claim to have some experience with the craft of game mastering.

Most recently I have create a website for players in my local group which you can view here: https://softwarewolf.org if you're curious.

I hope you have fun with this material and invite you to comment.

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Note

This module is for use by Game Masters. If a GM is going to be running this for you then please do not read any further.

Overview

The contents of this adventure are not meant to be campaign or game system specific. You can swap people and places from anywhere in your campaign with the ones listed here or use this without modification as you wish. In the descriptions of people, creatures, items, etc., I use generic terminology that can be used to translate these descriptions into stats for the game system of your choice. Feel free to make adjustments to anything here in order to integrate this adventure into your own world or to suit your tastes. You should read through this material, note your changes, what you wish to emphasize in the material, and any game stats that you or your players might need.

In the following pages we will describe a city where the adventure takes place, important locales, the people involved, and a rough timeline of events that unfold to bring the story to a conclusion. Of course your players may have other ideas. Remember what they say about the best laid plans of mice and men...

Prologue

Richard Cotta, a frustrated commoner, sought to become a merchant and work his way up the ranks to eventually hobnob with the rich and famous. He was unsuccessful and eventually denied mobility up from the middle class as he lacked the social graces to befriend those in the upper ranks. His frustration grew into a seething hatred and he determined to have his revenge on the city that shunned him.

Seeking a darker path to power he sought a deal with a devil as a means he could use to accumulate the power he desired. You can change means that Mr. Cotta used to become a wererat including: He was attacked by a wererat and simply took advantage of his newfound powers, a deal was made with a dark power which imbued/cursed him with lycanthropy, he hired a morally questionable wizard to transform him. Any of these choices could lead to additional adventures outside the scope of this module and with additional preparation could be added to your campaigns plot lines.

The villain then studied rattus lycanthropy to gain every possible advantage of his new condition. Richard learned of a cheese made by a creamery outside the city that had a particular effect on rodents granting him even more control over them than his lycanthropy did. This discovery fitted into his plans by allowing him to turn citizens the city into his lycanthropic thralls. The first person he turned was Remy Stilton, the scion of a wealthy business owner who had previously been Richards boss. After that, Remy became a front for Richard with Richard remaining in the shadows while Remy became the face of what would became the cult of the rat god. Now people from all walks of life would be quietly converted into wererats and controlled by Remy, who is controlled by Richard, and when the time was right a coup would be staged that would topple the city!

The City of Everward

The city of Everward is a large, prosperous, coastal city-state ruled by King Benjamin Monroe. Discreetly referred to as Benjamin the fat or less discreetly as the Merchant King. King Benjamin is known for his political and business acumen and preference for favoring deals and alliances over military might.

Districts

Everward is divided into several districts. It's laws govern what sort of commerce and activities are allowed in each. Listed in order of wealth and influence they are:

- The Palace District – The main keep of the city, the manor of the king, several official offices

and the residences of the most wealthy and important citizens are located here. The royal guard is also garrisoned here.

- The Merchant District – The cities guild halls, the high market, all of the high value shops, and lesser administration offices, and the homes of the people who work here are in this district.
- Star Street – Between the merchant district and the emerald quarter. Not officially a district but administered as one with business that are not allowed in either of its surrounding districts. Known for its two prestigious brothels and apothecary specializing in recreational potions.
- The Emerald Quarter – The residential area of the wealthy.
- The Commons – The residential area of the middle class, the location of the University of Everward, The small market, the sanatorium (hospital), many business, inns and taverns.
- The Lilac Quarter – Ironically named district for the lower class and businesses that would be undesirable elsewhere (i.e. tanneries).
- The Canals – A collection of canals runs between the docks and the commons sometimes passing through the lilac quarter. There are enough statues regulating the canals that they are considered their own district. There are parts of the canals that used to go through the emerald quarter and the palace district but criminal activities led the authorities to block off the canals before those districts. Most of those unused segments have been filled or partially filled in.
- The Docks – Separated into the upper docs where merchant traffic flows and the lower docs where fishing vessels set sail and return, the docs are a hub of activity. Some inns and taverns as well as a few businesses such as shipwright, sail makers, and rope makers.

The Story

The adventure takes place mostly in the city of Everward, a large mercantile city. When the story begins Richard Cotta, a wererat, has begun his plans to take over the city. After abandoning his previous life as a middle class merchant, he now resides in an upper class neighborhood. Richard's first conversion was Remmy Stilton. Remy Stilton is the apparent leader of the wererats, with none of the other lycanthropes aware of Richard or of his control of Remy. Remy is a member of the Stilton family, the owners of a chain of successful inns. While the Stilton family is concerned about Remy, he has disappeared a few times in the past to indulge his vices and so they have only recently alerted authorities as he has been absent longer than he had during any previous binge.

Citizens from several districts have been converted into wererats under Remy's control. The means of control is Le'feite farms private reserve cheese. This pungent cheese is made on the Le'feite farm in limited quantity and in high demand by the upper class in the city. Rick, the actual leader of the wererats, has learned that by giving or withholding the cheese from the other wererats they will willingly submit to his commands.

Those turned into wererats become members of the cult of the rat god. Originally its ideology shifted to whatever was convenient for Rick and Remy. Cult members were too dependent on their cheese fix to be concerned with inconsistencies in it's messages. Recently a rat god, a demigod has felt the supplications of the worshipers of this new cult and bestowed a measure of its divinity to the faithful. Now there are a few real priests of the rat god and Rick and Remy are unsure how to handle this. At present they have an unspoken agreement with the shaman of the rat god to stay out of each others way.

By the time the characters become engaged in the events of the story, Richard Cotta working through Remy Stilton will have turned a few agents in several districts of the city and will be looking to broaden their power base by accumulating wealth and influence.

Entering the adventure

The player characters will enter the city under normal circumstances (looking to spend recently acquired wealth, rest up before starting a new adventure, looking to purchase some goods only available in a large city). After spending a little time in town they will notice some or all of the following:

- Rats appearing with increased frequency over time
- The prevalence of damage caused by rats including holes in walls, gnaw marks on packages
- Posted requests for additional rat catchers and 'rats in the cellar' type bounties
- Posted notices around town regarding missing items of various value with rewards for return. This sort of notice is fairly common but the number of them is rather high.
- A slightly higher than average number of notices of missing persons that one would expect
- Graffiti in thieves script offering a bounty for information on the perpetrators of unauthorized thievery around town.

If either of the requests for rat catchers or 'rats in the cellar' type bounties are taken up by the PCs they will find some rats in expected places but more evidence of large numbers of rats passing through or, if they take several jobs, see signs of rats cycling from location to location as though they were somehow organized. Tracking rats will lead to unusually large groups of rats converging on the sewers.

Questioning the locals

Questioning the locals my turn up additional information including:

- In poorer areas
  - Sightings of people trading in illicit goods who are not members of gangs
  - A person being carried off by individuals or a small person being carried away by rat swarms
  - An oddly shaped bit of low quality ivory (a rodent tooth the size of a forefinger)
  - Patches of fur whose length suggests an animal the size of a wolf. Though PCs familiar with animals will not recognize the type of fur.
- In other areas
  - Excessive losses of goods caused by vermin
  - Folk who have disappeared and reappeared after a few days.
  - Foiled and successful attempts at breaking and entering. If criminal connections are checked, most of these attempts were not sanctioned break ins.
  - Graffiti involving rats and threatening messages.

While going about their investigation, a posting for a highly profitable, short term merchant guard job will catch the PCs attention. Several local taverns who specialize in high quality meals have pooled funds to ensure the safe delivery of private reserve cheese from the Le'feite farm creamery. As the farm is only a half days ride from the city and the bounty is high the party would need to speak to one of the tavern keepers listed in the post quickly before someone else takes it.

Taking the job

If the party takes the job, they will be given instructions that includes pickup of Le'feite farms private reserve cheese (enough to occupy a small cart). The trip to the farm will be uneventful. However soon after the party begins the return trip they will be waylaid by a group of wererats looking to steal the cheese. The lycanthropes will ambush the party in a location with several places for concealment and multiple possible exits. All of the creatures will be in their hybrid form when they attack. The monsters party will consist of several wererat warriors armed with short swords and short bows or similar weapons and one or two wererat scouts. Additionally, there will be some wererats with combat skill on par with the PCs and one or two who are powerful in comparison to the party. In all this should be an average challenge for the party.

Points of note:

- Prior to initiating combat, several of the wererats will take potions that improve their combat ability in various ways (better attack, damage, toughness, or movement). The more competent creatures will also have a few potions of healing and smoke bombs for escape.
- The wererat scouts will summon rat swarms when the combat begins to distract spell casters or PCs who rely on mobility.
- If all of the higher level wererats are disabled or killed, the remaining ones will lose control and go after the cheese unless its rind is undisturbed.
- If the rind on the cheese is broken deliberately by the PCs the wererats will have difficulty following orders and may break ranks to possess it.
- Should the fight go poorly for the monsters they will shape change into large rats and disappear down tunnels in the ground too small for the PCs to follow. If there are some tiny PCs in the group who could follow either have them attacked in the tunnel or follow the rats to a spot some distance away where they surface and return to the city.

Failing to take the job

Should the party ignore the post of wait too long before taking the job the following events will unfold:

- A small group of locals will pick up the job
- The locals will get to the farm, pick up the cheese, and not be heard from again.
- Concerned family members and the collection of tavern owners will post for information on the group with emphasis on either the people or the merchandise based on who's post is being read.
- If an investigation of the guards is undertaken, the location of a fight not far outside the Le'feite farm will be located. The fight will have been hastily cleaned with evidence indicating that the guards were killed. Tracks from the fight will lead to where the guards bodies are buried and then back towards the city. If the trackers are especially skilled, they will find that the tracks lead to the sewers where they can no longer be followed.

Nifkin Grundlehammer

This location and NPC is optional. Nifkin Grundlehammer has a small hay and dairy farm just outside the Le'feite farm. The farm mostly sells hay to the Le'feite farm and occasionally provides milk for lower quality cheeses when the Le'feite farm is running low. The hay fields all have scarecrows in them. If any of the PCs are being especially observant they will notice that the main house is on the small side and the two workers cottages appear to be unoccupied. Someone familiar with farming would

know that it would not take many people to manage the few fields and cows on the farm. A single hard working family could handle it.

The sole occupant of the farm is Nifkin Grundlehammer, a “retired” artificer who managed to preserve his existence if not his life by transferring his soul into a wooden likeness of an old man. He will conceal this from the party. Nifkin prefers not do deal with strangers and but will answer questions to avoid looking suspicious. The craftsmanship of the doll housing his soul is excellent and an observer would need to look closely to notice that he was made of wood. If confronted about the lack of workers on his farm he will state that they have gone to town for a weekend but are expected to return in a day. If charged with being a construct, he will admit that he is a human in a wooden body.

His story is that he had been a successful artificer and occasional adventurer as needed to obtain rare materials for his work. He had been attacked in his previous home by thieves looking rob him. After leaving him for dead, he was able to get to his workshop and animate the wooden body he now occupies. In his current form he lacks the dexterity to fashion a better puppet that would allow him to continue his previous work (this is a lie). Now he can accomplish only a fraction of what he once could (again lying).

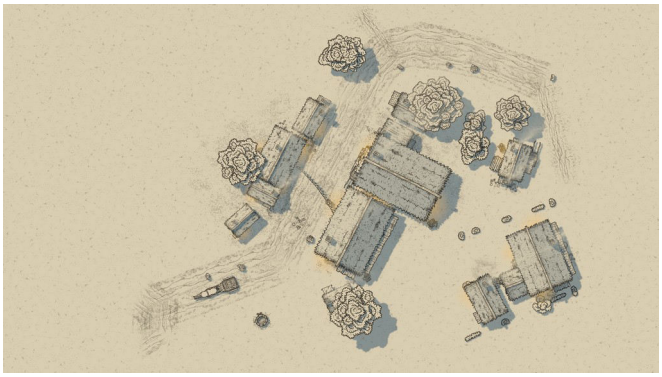
A party member might recall a story about a group of adventurers who collected a bounty on an artificer whose inventions had been used to raze several villages elsewhere in the kingdom. It is possible that a well informed PC might be able to link Nifkin's tale with actual events and determine that he is the artificer mentioned in those events.

If confronted Nifkin will admit that he was the artificer in those rumors but that he had been framed for the crimes by the actual artificer who committed them. If the party gives any indication that they mean him harm he will have everything nearby that can move immediately attack the party and hold them off while he retreats to safety inside the house. Once inside he can get into any number of concealed spaces that would be very difficult to locate while allowing him to continue to use any number of nearby props, even the house itself, to attack the PCs.

He can also summon a small army of cloth dolls to do his bidding as well. While not particularly useful in a fight they can get in the way and cause more than a little chaos during a fight. Just about any piece of furniture, bit of construction, or tool can be animated at his will. For example having the fence grab and hold someone, a horse trough that spills enough water to cause a fall or attempts to drown a victim, a wind chime that makes enough noise to make communication or spell casting difficult. When desperation rears its head Nifkin will enter the farmhouse and it will then animate and attempt to contain and crush interlopers.

Nifkin supplies those who can afford his services with magic items. Mostly traps and small dangerous items. He has recently been supplying the wererats with magical items.

Le'feite Farm



A half days ride from Everward lies the pastoral Le'feite Farm. A milk farm and creamery. The farm is quite large with a few small houses and bunk houses for the staff scattered around the farm near the various areas where work is done. Near the road that passes by the farm is the main entrance where two large buildings for the creamery, the Le'feite family house, housing for

staff, and workshops are located. Cattle surround the buildings.

Visitors to the farm are greeted by what appears to be a well spoken and well kempt farm hand who is actually one of the guards on the farm. The guards are trained in showing curious guests around while keeping an eye on them and keeping them from restricted areas. After a brief tour guests will be directed to a terrace built for gatherings where they may rest and take a simple meal. Time for serving small groups of guests is factored into the kitchen staffs schedule. After resting and perhaps a meal, guests will be invited to leave.

The matriarch of the farm is Amy Steke-Le'feite. She runs the farm efficiently and has put competent people in charge of various aspects creamery work. Each section reports to Amy directly and she grants them wide latitude in administering their operations.

Madame Le'feite is a widow with no children and no apparent interest in starting a family. Her personal secretary Jasmine Guyere is assumed to be her heir as she has been apprenticed by Amy in the farms operations. Amy is not cold but business like and will not brook any overly long conversation or attempt at dishonesty. The farm's fame has made her very well connected in Everward and crossing her would lead to several complications in the city.

The boss of the guards is Rick O'shea. Unlike other guards, he wears light armor and openly carries weapons while on duty. Other guards who are on duty and not escorting guests also wear light armor and various weapons.

Nearest the compound are a few modest plots set aside for crops for the workers. Beyond that are areas for cattle and the cultivation of hay. A few seasonal ponds dot the grounds and are used by the cattle when full.

People who may be met at the farm include:

- Bessie Milker – Milk maid
- Mark Mender – Farrier and handyman.
- Bucky Buster and Drover Stockman – Cowherds

Additional Complications

Events can occur on or near the creamery include:

- A fire in a barn or other building (accidental or arson)
- The farm guards ejecting a 'guest' who is behaving inappropriately
- A chance encounter with a notable person on their way to or from the creamery.

Concerned Merchants

The shortage of Le'feite Farm reserve cheese is of concern to the owners of some of the higher quality inns, taverns, and merchants in Everward. Party members could contact or be contacted by any individual merchant to make a deal to ensure that their interest in getting the cheese has primacy or that other people of interest do not obtain cheese immediately. Additionally Arthur Slugworth, a rival cheese maker could contact or be contacted by the party to ensure that either the Le'feite creamery is sabotaged or destroyed.

The Sewers

The city sewers are a large collection of passages, filters, processors, storage rooms, and occasional workshops that lie beneath the city. Drains from the streets and larger buildings filling tanks that send the waste water to filters, processors, other tanks, and eventually the bay. There are many entrances to the sewers though they are all off limits and anyone entering them who do not work for the city will be prosecuted if caught. The fear of prosecution does not deter folk who are looking to make use of the passages under the city for their own purposes though.

When describing the sewers be sure to describe it so that you convey the dark and disgusting conditions of

the sewers. A short distance after moving away from any light source the tunnels will be pitch black. The sounds of dripping and running water comes from several directions confusing the sense of sound. Differing smells of varying intensity waft through the air and are pushed on by the water. Odd, discarded things can be seen floating by. This might be an opportunity to throw out a random “interesting” item if the players are willing to pick it up.

Odd, random things

Any number of strange things can be found in the sewers if one searches long enough. Check periodically to see if the party comes across something odd such as:

- An enormous femur
- The steel pommel of a sword with a faint magical aura.
- A wedding ring
- A wedding ring attached to a finger
- A patch of mushrooms that give the appearance of a small village
- A glass eye (make the discovery of this creepy)
- A single cockroach of large size that is impossible to catch or strike that follows the party until they leave the sewer
- An inky black puff of smoke that appears unmoving until touched when it will dissipate.
- Two blind mice and a third that is faking it.
- A discarded box of cheap perfumes.

Consider adding properties to any of these finds if that works for you.



There are several encounters that can occur in the sewers. How/when/if they occur is your call. Add any or all of them in as you feel appropriate.

Run in with ne'er-do-wells

Here are two sample scenarios for encountering thieves in the sewers.

1. A party of rogues is combing the sewers looking for thieves who are working the city without permission. They are not yet aware that the people they are search for are wererats. The rogues will be moving in stealth and familiar with the area.

2. A party of rogues is using the sewers as a means of getting to or from a job. They will be moving in stealth and aware of the layout of area of the sewers they are in. Their target should be determined in advance:

- A wealthy merchant's home. The target would be general loot and one or two named items.
- The university. The target would be specific ongoing research, old documents, or a hit on a specific faculty member.
- A wizard. The target would be one of their spell books, a magic item, or a hit on the wizard.
- A rival group of rogues. The target would be to destroy their base of operations, plant incriminating evidence, or a hit on the group.

It will be assumed that the PCs are hostile and they

will attack from stealth. Combat options at their disposal include:

- Knowledge of side passages and hiding spots that would be difficult to detect.
- Knowledge of locations of excessive noise where sneaking is easier
- Access to mechanisms that would produce a gush of water that would swamp or sweep away the PCs.

Crabs

The city does indeed have crabs in its sewers. They are a hearty breed who can survive the polluted waters and have adapted to this environment. Some of the largest crabs have a shell as large as an adult human and are occasionally covered in smaller crabs.

Multiple magical beasts

Achibald the wizard is conducting illegal magical experiments. As they have no stealthy way of removing evidence of their work they are casting it into the sewers. Any sort of magical or altered beast might be encountered in the sewers. Feel free to make up something interesting. Creatures that could not survive the environment would die near the sewer entrance where they were dumped. This could lead to an entire side quest going into the wizards lab and house. Unless irrefutable evidence were presented to the law the wizard would be justified in defending themselves and bringing the law down upon the intruders. Archibald is well connected in the city.

Unnoticed encounters with rats

The sewers have always been populated by rats and encountering a few would be considered an ordinary occurrence. Most of the time one would pass by without noticing a rat or two. This works in the wererats favor as the rats are used to give an early warning to their masters and can be commanded to do various tasks as needed. A rat under the control of a wererat could sneak onto an adventurer and possibly steal or ruin a small item. A strap could be mostly gnawed through so that it breaks at an inopportune moment for the PC. Other creatures could be guided to the PCs.

A party may encounter a rat swarm. Either one or more that had been sent after the group if they had been noticed, or a single rat swarm at random. A rat swarm covers an area of different sizes from as small as the area occupied by a single character to as large as a the entirety of a small room. The swarm will make an amount of noise appropriate to its size and be either running towards the party to attack or towards the party to avoid something more dangerous.



Rat swarms can not be killed by striking individuals, at least not without innumerable blows the to swarm over a long period of time. A swarm can not be drowned, though they can be shaken off an individual who submerges. Being swarmed by rats causes a reduction of vision, a fear response (the inability to do anything other than strike at the swarm ineffectively, run, scream uncontrollably, etc.). Even if a swarmed individual is not subject to harm they will be hampered by the swarm, with reduced combat ability, inability to cast spells, or other impediments. A swarmed individual may contract a random disease if it is possible that they could be harmed by the swarm. Swarms are affected by things that have an area of effect which should also affect anyone inside the swarm.

Noxious air

There are a few rare places in the sewers that have been neglected by maintenance crews where the air is filled with noxious fumes. This air can cause mild to severe nausea, either making any actions by the characters difficult to preventing the characters from taking any action until they are removed from the area.

Wererats, normal rats, rat swarms, and many monster types are unaffected by noxious air.

Encounters with wererats

Either a chance encounter or a group directed to hunt the PCs could be encountered. If a chance encounter, then the group should be an easy combat for the PCs. If it's a hunting party then the NPCs should be a difficult encounter for the PCs. Assume any wererats encountered in the sewer have the same combat options available as the ne'er-do-wells described earlier. If the encounter is a wererat ambush then the wererats may have used the secret tunnels that originate in the assembly. The wererats shouldn't be so stupid as to give away the tunnel entrance by attacking from the the tunnel entrance. The party might find such an entrance by searching. See the section on the assembly for additional information.

Magical Traps

Nifkin Grundlehammer has been supplying the wererats with magical traps. Many of these have been placed in locations with other hazards such as sewer crabs, noxious air, near lairs, or some combination of these. These traps would hold intruders, make loud noises to alert those nearby, cause chemical or mechanical damage, blind, or a combination of these.

Miscellaneous wererat lairs

Hidey Holes – Simple out of the way locations that one or more wererats would hide or sleep in. There is a chance of simple items being left here for later use such as blankets or food.

Sentry – A spot where one to four wererats would be stationed to guard a specific location. These are rarely permanent. Objects in the area would include weapons, food, lanterns or torches, and some tools to create or clear obstructions.

Lair – A common area for sleeping, cooking, and simple tasks. One might find bedding, chairs, tables, books, lanterns, tools, cookware, and other supplies.

The Shrine

A shrine to the rat god has been created in what used to be a larger maintenance room in the sewers. Remy Stilton directed the creation of the shrine though he had no idea that there really was a rat god. The place was used in part as a means to control the other wererats over the long term. Shortly after the shrine was completed, the devotion of the wererats attracted the attention of the rat demigod and now the group has a couple of shaman capable of wielding some magical power. This has taken Remy and Rick aback and they are currently deciding what, if anything to do about this unexpected event.

When the party reaches the shrine there should be several wererats and one or two shaman there. Any wererat shaman near the shrine will have additional spells and power available and any other wererats will receive some minor protection and assistance from the rat god as well.

The Assembly

As no appropriate space was to be found in the sewer, a part of a sewer wall has been dug out and a room for assembling all of the wererats has been carved out of the hard clay beneath the city. The entrance is simply a large hole in the sewer wall but the room inside appears to have been worked by carpenters and brick layers. It's not lavish but it is functional with rows of benches and a raised podium at the far end. A few alcoves containing poor quality tapestries that conceal tunnels that run to several locations in the sewers. These tunnels can be used to ambush the party at any

point if the GM desires to do so.

If the party enters the assembly using stealth, they will find the bulk of the wererats eating, maintaining gear or spending time with each other. If the party has caused any commotion before arriving (most likely) then the Wererats will be prepared to fight and in an advantageous position when the party arrives.

Due to their addiction to Le'feite cheese, the wererats will fight until all of the leaders and higher level NPCs are killed or incapacitated.



The Boss Battle

Near Remy's private room a section of wall has been hewed out into a rough cavern. After earlier encounters with wererats, Remy will prepare an ambush there. Creatures encountered in the cavern include:

- Wererat warriors
- Wererat scouts
- High level wererat scout with several items made by Nifkin Grundlehammer
- Wererat shaman
- High level wererat shaman
- Gelatinous Cheese Blob controlled by High level wererat shaman.
- A wererat mage with cheese based versions of spells also known as Tyromancy.
- A giant wererat berserker.
- Remmy Stilton, the false wererat leader
- The Gorgon-zola a cheese powered mechanical bull. Smaller than a full sized bull but still very tough.

See the Creature Details section for more information on these.

This encounter should be an ambush, though the party might catch on before it is too late to react. The warriors will rush out first

Remy's private room

This room might or might not be located until after the fight in the assembly. It is a large store room that has been converted into his private living quarters. In the room there is a proper bed, nightstand, and wardrobe containing attire for being above ground in human form and for being below group in rat human hybrid form. A basin and pitcher of fresh water is on a small table of the side of the bed opposite the night stand. The nightstand contains some papers which are instructions from Richard Cotta given to Remy on different occasions. Each paper is signed R.C. One of the papers is a map to the drop point for the reports that he is to make to R.C. every week. A note on the map states that the reports are to be delivered to the drop point weekly.

The party can stake out the drop point but the note on the map does not state which day the reports are to be delivered. It might take up to a full week of surveillance to see a pickup at the drop point. Read the section *Exiting the sewers before dealing with the boss* if the party does not finish the boss fight.

Chests containing the funds used to support and expand the group are here as well as any expensive supplies that they might need. There is a small vent to the surface that provides fresh air into the room as

well.

Exiting the sewers before dealing with the boss

Should the party exit the sewers before winning the fight against Remy Stilton the wererats will regroup, rearm, heal, and move their lairs. Additionally, Remy and Richard Cotta will use their influence to rally the city against the party by spreading rumors, lies, and paying 'witnesses' to speak against them.

Aftermath of dealing with the wererats



If Remy is killed or captured he will be carrying a letter with orders about organizing the wererats, how to provision them without attracting overt attention from the city and a list of the next people to kidnap and convert. Also he will be carrying a some coins, wearing a few pieces of jewelry, and carrying a key to a sewer store room that has been converted into his private room. It will be signed only with the initials R.C.

City Guard

The city guard have a headquarters in the Merchant District though each district has a guard station where the local guards receive their daily orders. These stations range from well appointed offices in the Merchant District to a gazebo in the docks. A Sargent is in charge of each district on each shift with the exception of Merchant's District which houses the Captain of the City Guard, Dick Tate, and Sargent's Jess Typhlotic, Pat Downe, and Sid Downe. These Sargent's travel between the districts assisting (more or less) the local guard.

While moving about the city one will notice that guards usually travel in pairs. When guards are called for they will generally arrive within a minute or two. Longer if summoned in poorer districts.



Additional Wererats

Should the party make multiple incursions into there sewers, wererat agents of Remy Stilton will be alerted and looking to complicate or prevent the party from their investigation of the sewers.

Wererat agents working in the city will be unlikely to use their wererat abilities to do so. Rather they will drum up some reason to alert the city guard or rile up locals using false rumors against the party.

Creature Details

Crabs

Only rumored on the surface are the existence of crabs in the sewers. Rumors regarding them are disregard as untrue. In fact crabs to dwell in the sewers and have for a considerable time. They range in size from larvae to the size of a draft horse.

The smallest crabs are found where the water is most still. A character without an appropriate background would not be able to recognize crab larvae as such. They just look like bugs.

Mature crabs range from 4” (10 cm) to 6” (15 cm) and they rarely live long enough to grow larger than that. Sewer crabs are found in groups and are also cannibalistic.

Larger crabs do exist and can be found in groups of 2-3 when they are 1'-5' (30-150 cm) across. Crabs of this size will only be found in sections of the sewer where the water is deep or while hunting prey outside of their lair. If they grow larger they will be solitary.

Multiple Magical Beasts

A wizard in Everward is experimenting with animals, beasts, and alchemy in his home laboratory. Eventually all of his creations are disposed of through a passage under his lab into the sewer. Many of these subjects are dead by the time they are disposed of. Some manage to survive in the sewers and almost anything could have come out of the lab.

Gelatinous Cheese Blob

One of the creatures created and discarded by Archibald the wizard was a perpetually melting, animated cheese. Remy found this and brought it to the shaman who manipulated it until it grew quite large. Consider it a gelatinous cube in all respects that additionally it is scorching hot and will burn anyone touching its surface or engulfed by it. It can also squeeze through tight spots in pursuit of prey. It is under the control of the shaman and will be brought into the boss fight.

When brought into the fight use the phrase “It's a gouda time for reinforcements.”

The Gorgonzola

A mechanical bull powered by fondue. Consider it a Gorgon, though it is about half the size of an ordinary one. It's power source is burning cheese in a boiler that will explode upon death hurling shrapnel and melted cheese in a wide area. Once wounded the boiler can be targeted if it is noticed.

It was created by Nifkin Grundlehammer for the wererats and it will be controlled by Remy or the next highest ranking wererat who is not a shaman. Picking over it's remains might lead to the discovery of a small makers mark on some part.

When brought into the fight use the phrase “Release the gorgonzola”

Wererats

As an organization, the wererats are tightly controlled by Remmy Stilton and he will in turn be controlled by Richard Cotta. Though the group has evolved into a religious cult more by accident than by design. References to the wererats as a group use the term group and cult interchangeably. By the time the adventure begins there should be several wererat infiltrators in the poorer districts of town with fewer in each district as the wealth of those districts increases. The types of people inducted would include gang members, tavern workers, laborers, a some journeymen craftsmen, a few influential (wealthy) people, and an alchemist, Aaron Morter. The plan is to convert more powerful people over time without raising suspicion. The game may start earlier or further along the timeline so there may be more or less infiltration into the city as the GM pleases.

There are individuals of varying power levels, with most being a lesser challenge to the PCs. Remmy has arranged to marshal the groups resources to provide accommodation for the current group with room for new members as needed. Caches of clothes, weapons, food, and additional equipment are hidden around the sewers as Remmy sees fit to distribute. These stores are part of the long term plan for the group.

As a species, wererats are lycanthropes whose appearance can vary between human, giant rat, and human-rat hybrid. The effects of this type of lycanthropy on its victims includes:

- The ability to see in the dark
- Enhanced smell, tracking ability

- Infectious bite. Disease, and possibly lycanthropy transmission
- Infectious proximity (disease, not lycanthropy, transmission via flea bites)
- Improved stealth
- Enhanced dexterity
- Control over rats and swarms of rats.
- Paranoia (don't overdo it)
- Greed (don't overdo it)
- Vulnerability to silver

The types of disease transmitted through bites and fleas might vary from individual to individual. Wererats in their human form can reduce or eliminate the possibility of infecting other via flea bites by bathing regularly. This is commonly done to help conceal their lycanthropic nature.

Control of rats and swarms of rats pertains to normal rats. More powerful wererats have better control, and can control swarms of rats or giant rats. Less powerful wererats can only control individual rats.

The transformation between forms is either voluntary for more powerful were creatures, involuntary during a full moon, or both. You might find it more convenient to have all of the wererats in this story to have full control over their form, possibly through their consumption of Le'feite cheese or some other mechanism.

Wererat warriors

Wererat warriors have all of the characteristics of a normal wererat but have advanced attributes, skills, and equipment when compared to other wererats. You could expect a wererat warrior to possess some light armor, perhaps a helmet, and certainly a weapon or two. Usually a sword, short sword, short spear, or crossbow. It is likely that they would possess weapons appropriate to what they would be using in there human form in the city. A variety of levels of warriors exists within the group with more powerful warriors possessing higher quality items and perhaps a few alchemetical items as well.

Higher level wererat warriors possess the same sorts of skills a higher level adventurer warrior might. They would tend towards skills involving agility or tricks.

Most of the high level wererat warriors will possess masterwork or minor magical weapons. Some of which might be broken or out of charges.

Wererat warriors do not summon rat swarms.

Wererat Scouts

Wererats are stealthy by nature but these are especially skilled in concealment, information gathering, and ambush. Often encountered alone, one will watch a party, gather information about them and either take it back to the cult or snipe and run. They will make full use of their knowledge of the sewers, trap locations, and the locations of other hazards and creatures in the sewers. A single scout will also be attached to patrol groups. A scout will have light armor at best, small weapons, and possibly some alchemetical items.

Higher level wererat scouts will have improved statistics, increased stealth ability, and higher quality weapons of masterwork quality or of a minor magical nature.

Most wererat scouts will have stolen items in their possession that are listed as missing on message boards around the city. Rewards for their return will be available.

Wererat scouts can summon rat swarms.

Wererat Shaman

The appearance of wererat shamans were a surprise to Remmy and Richard Cotta. They were an unintended consequence of forming a false rat cult that actually attracted the attention of a minor rat deity. In most aspects shamans will be similar to wererat scouts

while also being able to cast spells consistent with the domain of a minor rat god. Additionally they might possess minor magic items with abilities such as minor healing, silence, and fear.

While shamans do not speak of it, they inherently distrust Remmy and are aware that the cult was originally a sham. They do not partake of the Le'feite Farms reserve cheese, are not under it's influence and do not take orders from Remy. There is an uneasy truce between them that the other wererats are unaware of. They will fight for cult and even fight to protect patrols in the sewer and even Remy should the situation call for it.

The spells available to wererat shaman include healing, various statistic or armor buffs, curses, blindness, illusions, and other spells as appropriate.

Higher level wererat shaman will cast higher levels of the spells mentioned earlier and in addition be wearing blessed rags that add armor, and carrying blessed staffs that enhance their spell casting and defend against magic. The blessings are removed when the wererat owner dies or the items are removed from them.

Wererat shaman can summon rat swarms freely and without penalty.

Wererat Tyromancer

One of the wererats is actually a mage who had been one of the original converts (a lucky find by Richard Cotta). This unfortunate was a wizard on their way to a short engagement at the university as a scholar. Other details on this individual can be created by the GM as needed.

The rat mages addiction to Le'feite Farms reserve cheese has compelled them to study alternate versions of their spells leading to the creation of tyromancy, a cheese based form of magic. The tyromancer should be a challenge for the party and will be encountered in the boss fight.

The mage will possess tattered robes that still provide some magical protection, a wand of reversal that instantly changes the facing of the target 180 degrees (particularly useful if held until just before the target acts). This wand only has 2 uses before it becomes useless. A few other lower powered items should also be in the mages posession.

“Common” Wererats

Some of the wererats have no exceptional abilities above or beyond that gained from becoming a wererat. Remy is trying to use discretion when selecting new recruits so unskilled wererats will be few in number. These commoners will still have some desirable attribute, knowledge, connections, or resources that would not be beneficial in combat.

Remy Stilton

Remy is the leader of the wererats though Richard Cotta is his puppet master . Remy is the son of a wealthy businessman in the city and is considered missing by his family. He has access to some of the wealth he possessed in his earlier life though he now largely lives upon the proceeds of thievery conducted by the wererat scouts.

He exerts control over the wererats through persuasion, and the use of Le'Feite Farm private reserve cheese. Previously he had also been using the cult of the wererat. But now there are real wererat shaman and this is no longer tenable. The wererat shaman are not under his control and an unspoken agreement exists between them and Remy that he no longer speaks for the rat god and they will not attempt to turn the other wererats against him.

Remy was and still is a rogue and should be considered more of a conman than an actual thief. He does possess the skills of a thief though he is better at committing fraud. He will be wearing magical leather armor, a cloak that allows him to use his stealth ability at any time, even while being observed, and carrying a magical short sword that is poisoned.

Any wererats in the vicinity will protect Remy as he dispenses the cheese.

Richard Cotta

Richard is a cagey manipulator. He made a poorly worded deal with a devil for power over people and became cursed with lycanthropy. Upset with the bargain but still determined to use it, he laid out a plan to turn key inhabitants of the city into wererats under his control.

Richard lives in the city in human form with no one the wiser. Only Remy Stilton is aware that Richard is a wererat . After his cult of wererats began bringing in money he began living in one of the least expensive homes in the most expensive district of town. Richard tries to live low key but sometimes can not help himself and makes a display of his wealth. He tells his neighbors that he is living off 'family money' and is attempting to decide what sort of business to go into. Outside of conversations in passing, his neighbors have had little contact with him.

After the discovery of Le'feite Farm reserve cheese on wererats, he gave the secret to Remy Stilton who then proceeded to implement Richard's plan to take over the city.

Richard has Remy drop reports on progress regularly and has a separate drops for messages to and from Remy. He will go directly to Remy's private room for a 'chat' if there is a need.

Richard will almost never be found in the sewers and will not be in the boss battle. It is possible that the party might not even find evidence of Richard's existence or his place in the wererat hierarchy. If this happens the whole cycle will repeat.

Le'feite Cheese

Le'feite Farm reserve cheese is a pungent cheese of very high quality which is sought after by turophiles and chefs. Most people find the aroma disgusting. Rats and mice have a strong attraction to it and owners of the cheese are aware that precautions must be taken to preserve it from vermin and the public at large.

It is this effect that Richard Cotta sought to use to control fellow wererats. He experimented on the first wererat he turned, Remy Stilton, to see how susceptible he was to the cheese's influence. The results were amazing. By withholding or granting the cheese he could command nearly absolute obedience from a wererat. For some unknown reason Richard himself is immune to this effect.

Magical Mechanical Traps And Items

Nifkin Grundlehammer was making a fair profit producing items for the wererats. Some of these items included:

- An incense that emits an overwhelming reek that deters people from proceeding
- A glass bead that emits just enough light for a person with low light vision to see in pitch darkness
- The equivalent of a bear trap that can be placed underwater for concealment that will spring up to 10' (3 m) towards it's victim when triggered.
- A glue bomb that explodes when struck or thrown. Often stuck onto the sewer ceiling and triggered by a wererat throwing a knife or rock when a victim passes under it.
- A 'music box' that attracts crabs. Lots of crabs. Big crabs.
- A small device that looks like a gramophone that sounds like a distressed person. Used to lure the unwary.
- Triggered net launchers. Too bulky to be used by wererats but find for traps.
- Noise makers that alert others nearby. Often used with other traps.
- “Bridges” over parts of the sewer that collapse

when traversed. They look solid and are used in conjunction with other traps and creatures.

- A rack of hooked spikes that fire when triggered and are pulled back into the rack dragging the victim with them.
- A spherical device that produces a blinding flash upon impact.

Considerations

The recommended way to use this module is to read through it then take extensive notes detailing how various parts of the story and characters fit into your campaign. Following that a GM should write up the game specific attributes of the characters, creatures and items they will be using in the game.

Maps were not created for this module and the GM should consider drawing their own maps before beginning the game. Maps may be included in a future revision of this module.

Finally consider any spin-off adventures that may occur as the result of events in this game. Some possibilities include:

- Does one of the miscellaneous items found in the sewer lead to a different mystery
- The family of one of the wererats will be grateful for news of their loved one and will gift the party with an item leading to a new adventure.
- The family of one of the wererats will be furious at the news of their loved one and will begin complicating the parties lives.
- Magically inclined characters may purse the arcane art of Tyromancy (cheese based magic)
- Romance with one of the NPCs
- The improvement or decrease in the parties reputation due to the events of the adventure and the effects of that on the party.